WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-08-17 to 2026-08-23

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SUMMARY

This week's COMAP Journal Bot brief centers on the gap between what institutions say they optimize and what people actually experience. New work examines value tensions in X's feed algorithm, the durability of fact-checking, demand for moral-emotional content, the capture of participatory institutions, and the legitimacy challenges surrounding data sharing. Together, the papers offer a particularly useful cross-level view of how platforms, news practices, and governing arrangements earn-or lose-public trust.

Three threads stand out:

- Platform and information governance: algorithmic value alignment, durable corrections, moral-emotional selection, civic journalism, and transparency.
- Institutions and participation: captured participatory councils, long-run institutional divergence, and fairness research designed for policy and organizations.
- Measurement and policy trade-offs: population estimation without complete censuses, mobility data in epidemic models, urban inequality, and renewable-energy governance.

This digest was prepared on Sunday, 2026-08-23, before the coverage window closed at the end of the day. It reflects records available at collection time; publications appearing later may be recovered in a subsequent catch-up or late-additions section.

HIGHLIGHTS

Value misalignments in X's feed algorithm is a reflection of value tensions in engagement

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-08-17

Why it matters · Directly tests whether X's ranked feed reflects users' stated values and traces misalignment to the engagement signals that platforms optimize.

Open article →

Hold That Thought: Enhancing the Durability of Fact-Checking Effects Through Low-Cost Accuracy Reminders

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-08-21

Why it matters · Shows that inexpensive, well-timed accuracy reminders can more than double the persistence of fact-checking effects across topics and partisan identities.

Open article →

Rethinking Assumptions About Moral Content Selection: Moral-Emotional Content May Be Less Appealing Than Assumed

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-08-21

Why it matters · Separates the supply of moral-emotional political content from audience demand, challenging a common assumption about why outrage travels online.

Open article →

Captured participatory institutions: Theory and evidence from Venezuela's Consejos Comunales

AMERICAN JOURNAL OF POLITICAL SCIENCE · 2026-08-18

Why it matters · Explains when government-captured participatory institutions can still deliver development and when they become instruments of regime survival.

Open article →

What Do We Mean by Transparency? Conceptualizing and Operationalizing Transparency in Communication

COMMUNICATION RESEARCH · 2026-08-17

Why it matters · Provides a systematic conceptual map of transparency research and identifies where communication scholarship overweights information while neglecting power and values.

Open article →

An agenda for real-world fairness research to inform policy and organizations

NATURE HUMAN BEHAVIOUR · 2026-08-17

Why it matters · Sets a policy-facing agenda for studying fairness in real organizations, a useful bridge from abstract metrics to institutional practice.

Open article →

Advances in small area population estimation in the absence of national census data

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-08-21

Why it matters · Surveys new data and geospatial methods for estimating small-area populations where censuses are incomplete, outdated, or unavailable.

Open article →

What is the problem and what can be done when data sharing challenges public legitimacy?

NATURE COMMUNICATIONS · 2026-08-21

Why it matters · Frames resistance to cross-border and industry health-data sharing as a legitimacy problem rooted in profit, control, and responsive governance.

Open article →

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Previous Week Catch-Up

- Political Communication
- American Journal of Political Science
- Nature Human Behaviour
- Nature Communications
- Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences
- Science Advances
- Science
- Nature

COLLECTION SNAPSHOT

TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES
326	163	163
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES	**CURATED DIGEST BELOW**	**NOTE**
0	16 new, 36 catch-up, 0 late additions	These counts reflect the complete collected set before manual relevance filtering, while the attached PDF reflects the curated digest.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

Political Communication

Hold That Thought: Enhancing the Durability of Fact-Checking Effects Through Low-Cost Accuracy Reminders

2026-08-21 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2716761

Je Hoon Chae; Tim Groeling; Hyunjin (Jin) Song

University of California; Yonsei University

Abstract. Prior evidence suggests that fact-checking can update beliefs regarding factually incorrect information in the short term but its effects often decay rapidly. Such decay raises normative concerns about its sustainability and real-world impact. Here, we examine whether a cognitively efficient, low-cost intervention - called an "accuracy reminder" - can enhance the durability of fact-checking effects. In a large-scale pre-registered panel longitudinal experiment (N = 7,188), participants were randomly assigned to receive fact-checks and, under some conditions, follow-up prompts to reevaluate the same claim at interval-optimized time points. Across topical domains and partisan identities, reminder conditions produced durable belief correction effects lasting up to four weeks, more than doubling the persistence observed without reminders. Effects were robust across reminder frequency and timing, as well as against individual differences, suggesting implementation flexibility and theoretical generalizability. These findings identify retrieval-based reinforcement as a scalable means of sustaining factual belief correction and reinforcing shared factual baselines in spite of cognitive decay and partisan resistance.

Read article →

Rethinking Assumptions About Moral Content Selection: Moral-Emotional Content May Be Less Appealing Than Assumed

2026-08-21 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2715701

Isabella Rebasso; Yanna Krupnikov

University of Michigan; University of Vienna

Abstract. Recent work has shown that moral-emotional content spreads rapidly on social media platforms such as X (Twitter). These patterns have led to concerns that social media facilitates the spread of moral outrage - potentially exacerbating political conflict and animosity. While most past work has focused on the supply side of this phenomenon, i.e. the transmission of morally charged political content, we consider the demand side: do people actually want to see this type of content in their information environment? In this paper, we first theoretically contextualize the motivations to engage with or avoid moral-emotional content. Then, through three pre-registered studies conducted in the U.S. in 2022 and 2023, we test whether people actively choose information that includes moral-emotional elements. Contrary to our initial expectations, we find that participants do not actively select moral-emotional content compared to neutral or emotional content. Despite previous findings on transmission, our results suggest that people may not want to see this type of content in their information environment. By focusing on selection rather than transmission, the findings presented in this paper add another nuance to an ongoing debate on the prevalence and consequences of online political outrage.

Read article →

Assessing Civic Journalism Training: A Mixed-Method Applied Research Study

2026-08-18 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2715698

Joshua P. Darr; Susan Robinson

Syracuse University; University of Wisconsin

Abstract. This mixedmethod applied research study examines how audiences are responding to news stories that are shaped by retraining efforts to help American journalists rebuild audiences. We wanted to know: were these trainings working? Do audiences choose stories that were influenced by these trainings over more traditional elite-focused, problem-oriented, conflict-driven stories? Working with three newsroom-training organizations, we report the results of a series of conjoint experiments that test how well stories abiding by new journalistic techniques of engagement, solutions and "good-conflict" framing play with audiences. We then use the findings from seven focus groups (n = 49) with surveys to explain why people may have responded the way they did in the tests. We found that audiences overwhelmingly selected and appreciated the re-framed content and reported that it makes them trust the news brands more. The focus group participants claimed such content would entice them to become members, subscribe, or even donate to the mainstream brand - if they came across it. However, only a few of the participants said they had heard about the news outlet. Though the principles behind these trainings may seem counterintuitive to some journalists, they offer a potential path forward in uncertain times for local news.

Read article →

American Journal of Political Science

A theory of political divergence and gradual institutional change

2026-08-20 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70084

Clair Yang

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Abstract. Abstract Why do some societies succeed in breaking away from historical traditions while others remain trapped? This paper proposes a formal theory to investigate the interaction between shortrun and longrun political dynamics, highlighting a coevolution of political institutions and social structures. A society consists of various social groups, such as the rulers, the elites, and the commoners. Shortrun strategic considerations give rise to different coalitions among these groups, which determine not only political regimes but also redistribution policies. In the long run, these policies shape the accumulation of wealth and power, where small initial differences can lead to divergent paths of development. Finally, the paper examines three historical case studies on medieval Europe, imperial China, and the medieval Muslim world to illustrate potential pathways of longrun political development.

Read article →

Captured participatory institutions: Theory and evidence from Venezuela's Consejos Comunales

2026-08-18 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70077

Jared Abbott; Jose MoralesArilla

Department of Political Science California State UniversityLos Angeles Los Angeles California USA; Escuela de Gobierno y Transformacion Publica Tecnologico de Monterrey Ciudad de Mexico Mexico

Abstract. Abstract Can participatory institutions (PIs) facilitate development when captured by the government? We propose an original theoretical framework to investigate how changing incumbent priorities can shape the developmental and political effects of captured PIs. While patrons concerned with survival can force PIs to specialize in political activities, those pursuing regime consolidation may incentivize PIs to multitask, delivering developmental gains and political rewards. We deploy our framework to study Venezuela's Communal Councils. Leveraging differenceindifferences analyses, an original survey of Council participants, and 51 interviews with government officials and grassroots Communal Council members, we find that Councils yielded both economic and political returns during an early period marked by political stability and regime consolidation. However, as Venezuela's economic collapse pushed the government into an authoritarian survival mode,

Councils became politically specialized. While showing that captured PIs can foster development under certain circumstances, our findings cast doubt on PIs' developmentenhancing potential under autocracy.

Read article →

Communication Research

What Do We Mean by Transparency? Conceptualizing and Operationalizing Transparency in Communication

2026-08-17 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261470088

Wenjia Yan; Li Crystal Jiang; Yiqian Gao; Pingping Jia

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Abstract. By analyzing 164 articles from communication journals published between 2002 and 2024, this scoping review systematically investigates temporal trends, conceptualizations, and operationalizations of transparency research within communication studies. The analysis identifies three primary conceptual dimensions of transparency: (1) information, encompassing both visibility and interpretation; (2) relations, functioning as an intermediary between dialogue and power; (3) values and norms, reflecting the tensions between ethical ideals and institutional constraints. Operationalization of transparency has predominantly relied on informational measures, whereas relational and value-based dimensions remain comparatively underdeveloped. Increasing attention has been directed toward subjective stakeholder perceptions, emphasizing transparency as a dynamic and context-dependent construct. Overall, the findings indicate that transparency extends beyond a stable informational attribute to incorporate relational and normative functions, while its enactment remains fluid, contextually shaped, and susceptible to unintended consequences.

Read article →

Nature Human Behaviour

An agenda for real-world fairness research to inform policy and organizations

2026-08-17 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02557-7

Ernst Fehr; Keyu Wu

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

Nature Communications

What is the problem and what can be done when data sharing challenges public legitimacy?

2026-08-21 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77006-0

Klaus Hoeyer; Lea Skovgaard

Abstract. Surveys suggest that health data sharing with industry and across national borders challenges public legitimacy. We argue that this resistance reflects deeper concerns about profit motives and loss of control and provide guidance on responsive governance to ensure public trust.

Read article →

Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Advances in small area population estimation in the absence of national census data

2026-08-21 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2413993123

Andrew J. Tatem; Gianluca Boo; Heather R. Chamberlain; Christopher C. Nnanatu; Edith Darin; Douglas R. Leasure; Ortis Yankey; Assane Gadiaga; Sabrina Juran; Luis de la Rua Rodriguez; Jessica Espey; Attila N. Lazar

Demographic Science Unit, Nuffield Department of Population Health, University of Oxford; Latin America and the Caribbean Regional Office, United Nations Population Fund; WorldPop, Department of Geography and Environment, University of Southampton

Abstract. Population data at small area scales are essential for effective decision-making, influencing public health, disaster response, and resource allocation, among others. While national censuses remain the cornerstone of population data, they are often constrained by high costs, infrequent collection cycles, and coverage gaps, which can hinder timely data availability. To address these challenges, geospatial statistical approaches using limited microcensus surveys have been demonstrated as a reliable source, but the field has advanced substantially in recent years, with significant developments in both data sources and modeling methodologies. New approaches now leverage routine health intervention campaign data, satellite-derived settlement maps, and bespoke modeling approaches to produce reliable small area population estimates where enumeration is difficult or outdated. Various countries are applying these techniques to support census operations, health program planning, and humanitarian response. This manuscript reviews recent advances in "bottom-up" population mapping approaches, highlighting innovations in input data, modeling methods, and validation techniques. We examine ongoing challenges, including partial observation of buildings under forest canopy, population displacement, and institutional uptake. Finally, we discuss emerging opportunities to enhance these approaches through better integration with traditional data ecosystems, capacity strengthening, and coproduction with national institutions.

Read article →

Urban tree canopy fragmentation and child mortality in low- and middle-income countries

2026-08-21 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2606669123

Dengkai Chi; Daniel Richards; Gabriele Manoli; Jun Yang; John S. Ji; Ye Zhang; Brenda Lin; Amy Hahs; Congqiang Liu; Yue Zhu; Yeshan Qiu; Jing Wang; Paolo Burlando; Simone Fatichi; Puay Yok Tan

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Abstract. Exposure to urban green spaces is associated with lower risks of several leading causes of under-5 mortality (U5M). While urban development improves infrastructure, healthcare access, and socioeconomic conditions, rapid urbanization in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs) has also accelerated the loss and fragmentation of green spaces. Such fragmentation may weaken ecosystem services critical for child health and increase exposure to vector-borne infections, yet its implications for U5M remain poorly understood and must be weighed against the benefits of urbanization. Here, we quantified associations between urban tree canopy cover and canopy aggregation with all-cause U5M using individual-level longitudinal mortality data between 2000 and 2019 from 57 LMICs, and identified priority areas for expanding canopy cover and improving canopy aggregation across 98 LMICs using counterfactual scenario analyses. The association between canopy cover and U5M was nonlinear, with risk declining steeply at low-to-intermediate levels of canopy cover. At a given level of canopy cover, every 1% increase in tree-to-tree adjacency was associated with a 0.17% reduction in mortality risk (hazard ratio: 0.9983, 95% CI: 0.9972 to 0.9995). The largest contiguous high-priority areas were concentrated in the West Sudanian Savanna, the eastern Punjab region of Pakistan, and the Ganges-Brahmaputra Delta in Bangladesh, where high U5M burdens align with substantial potential to improve tree canopy. This study establishes a robust association between tree canopy characteristics and U5M across LMICs. We identify canopy cover and fragmentation as potentially

modifiable risk factors, highlighting important implications of urban greening design for delivering cobenefits for child health and climate mitigation.

Read article →

Characterizing the impact of incorporating spatially aggregated human mobility data into infectious disease models

2026-08-18 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2533465123

Ronan Corgel; Kyra H. Grantz; Lauren Gardner; Derek A. T. Cummings; Harendra de Silva; Thilini Somaratne; Dhammika Silva; LakKumar Fernando; Amy Wesolowski

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Abstract. Models of infectious disease dynamics should align the spatial scale of mobility data to the scale of travel relevant to inferring disease introduction events and subsequent local transmission. Despite this, the biases of spatially aggregating mobility data on model inferences are rarely explored. Here, we examine the sensitivity of infectious disease modeling results to different spatial scales of human mobility by integrating multiscale mobility data from Sri Lanka into Susceptible, Exposed, Infected, Recovered (SEIR) metapopulation models. Aggregated mobility data were obtained from mobile phone records at three increasingly coarser spatial scales to simulate epidemic spread of an emerging acute respiratory infection. We found that travel was not evenly distributed among nested spatial scales when data were disaggregated, with subunits close to borders exhibiting higher levels of travel relative to the unit. In simulations of disease transmission, these different scales of mobility aggregation had potential to yield wide variations in the estimated spatial invasion timing but not in final epidemic size. Modeled differences in spatial invasion time depended on disease transmission intensity and exogenous factors like the initial seeding location. Our results carry implications for infectious disease modeling best practices and public health response, particularly the policy decisions made from model inferences that were or were not informed by the relevant spatial scale of mobility data such as intervention timing, risk communication, and resource allocation.

Read article →

Value misalignments in X's feed algorithm is a reflection of value tensions in engagement

2026-08-17 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2610388123

Ziv Epstein; Farnaz Jahanbakhsh; Tiziano Piccardi; Axel Peytavin; Isabel Gallegos; Shardul Sapkota; Dora Zhao; Johan Ugander; Michael S. Bernstein

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Abstract. Social media feed algorithms rank content that is purported to be preferred by users, but the engagement behaviors that drive these algorithms are (at best) indirect proxies for users' explicitly self-stated values. Are the resulting feeds value aligned, and if not, why? We investigate this question by annotating the basic human values expressed in participants' X (Twitter) feeds (N = 715 US users), analyzing the relationship between the posts' value expressions and the posts' amplification in the ranked "For You" Page feed, and then comparing the amplified values to users' own values. We observe that the inventory of posts from followed accounts reflects users' self-stated values-but that there is an overall negative correlation (misalignment) between users' explicit values and the value expressions the algorithm is more likely to amplify. We turn to engagement behavior to understand this misalignment and observe that users' engagement behaviors can be misaligned with their stated values-likely causing the algorithm to learn and reflect these misaligned values. We also detect partisan differences consistent with this theory: While the algorithm amplifies values negatively correlated with both Democrats' and Republicans' self-stated values, they are more misaligned for Democrats. And in fact replying, a heavily weighted form of engagement, is associated with values that are less aligned for both Democrats' and Republicans'

self-stated values, and is even more misaligned for Democrats. Taken together, these findings offer a glimpse into the tensions between the values that people hold and those that provoke reactions, and how these value tensions can produce misaligned outcomes.

Read article →

Science

A Brussels Effect for battery sustainability

2026-08-20 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AED8133

Yanan Liang; Edgar Hertwich; Robert Istrate; Antonio Valente; Ranran Wang

Department of Energy and Process Engineering, Norwegian University of Science and Technology, Trondheim, Norway.; Institute for the Environment and Health, Nanjing University Suzhou Campus, Suzhou, China.; Institute of Environmental Sciences (CML), Leiden University, Leiden, Netherlands.; International Institute for Applied Systems Analysis, Laxenburg, Austria.; State Key Laboratory of Water Pollution Control and Green Resource Recycling, School of the Environment, Nanjing University, Nanjing, China.; ecoinvent Association, Zurich, Switzerland.

Abstract. An EU battery regulation can help drive toward a widely shared evidentiary system for sustainability governance

Read article →

Beyond carbon in renewable energy policy

2026-08-20 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEK1460

Yuanning Liang

School of Economics, Peking University, Beijing, China.

Abstract. China's policy-driven solar expansion shows why climate policy appraisal should look at biodiversity impacts

Read article →

China's solar expansion policy reduces bird diversity

2026-08-20 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEE0747

Huiming Zhang; Aixin Zhang; Kai Wu; Yinyin Cai; Shanjun Li; Shouyang Wang; Yueming (Lucy) Qiu; Shoujun Huang; Thi Thuc Anh Phan

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Abstract. Could the global transition to renewable energy create a green dilemma that pits carbon reduction against biodiversity conservation? This study examined the effect of policies promoting solar photovoltaics on local avian biodiversity using a panel dataset covering 2344 counties in China from 2014 to 2023. Policies that favored photovoltaic expansion led to reductions in bird diversity, disproportionately affecting wealthier and nondesert regions, as well as widespread species. The mechanism operated primarily through land conversion: Cropland and grassland were transformed into developed areas, reducing the diversity of vegetation. Paradoxically, the leaf area index increased, a pattern we term "inferior greening," whereby diverse natural landscapes were replaced by dense but ecologically homogeneous vegetation. We argue that future photovoltaic development should be accompanied by strict biodiversity safeguards, especially in economically developed regions with high habitat complexity.

Read article →

Nature

Asymmetric prefrontal representations for leader-follower dynamics

2026-08-19 · DOI 10.1038/S41586-026-10900-1

Yuan Cheng; Yusi Chen; Myungji Kwak; Ross P. Kempner; Rudramani Singha; Jared Winslow; Runqi Liu; Umais Khan; Tessa Spangler; Alvi Khan; Talmo Pereira; Matthew Whiteway; Evan S. Schaffer; Nuttida Rungratsameetaweemana; Nan Yang; Herbert Zheng Wu

Abstract. Across species, cooperative behaviour is often organized by distinct social roles such as leaders and followers1, yet the neural mechanisms that support these emergent role dynamics remain unclear. Here we introduce a mouse paradigm that captures leader-follower dynamics during cooperation. In this paradigm, stable social roles emerge through reciprocal interaction and predict learning speed. Disrupting the activity of the medial prefrontal cortex (mPFC), particularly in followers, impairs cooperation and induces complementary shifts in how animals weigh self- and partner-related cues during decision-making. Calcium imaging reveals that the mPFC represents leader-follower dynamics and computes an egocentric social value map of the partner's position in a role-dependent manner. By integrating these empirical findings with a multi-agent inverse reinforcement learning framework, we identify latent value functions that guide cooperative decisions and are decodable from mPFC activity. These findings identify prefrontal representations of leader-follower dynamics and partner information, revealing how social roles structure asymmetric yet reciprocal influence over joint decisions.

Read article →

Previous Week Catch-Up

Political Communication

Affective Legitimacy and Digital Populism: Evidence from Romania's Annulled Presidential Elections

2026-08-13 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2714818

Antonio Amuza; Vasile Dincu

University of Bucharest

Abstract. On 6 December 2024, Romania's Constitutional Court annulled the first round of presidential elections, triggering an exceptional crisis of democratic legitimacy in post-communist Europe. While procedurally justified, the decision sparked intense public reactions, both emotional and political. The findings confirm that populist interpretations of institutional actions proliferate in fragmented and emotionalized digital media environments, where distrust is personalized and intensified. Drawing on a nationally representative survey (N = 964), conducted by IRES shortly after the annulment, the study examines how Romanian citizens perceived the legitimacy of the Court's decision and identifies the key socio-political and media-related factors shaping these perceptions. Binary logistic regression and mediation models were used to assess the drivers of perceived illegitimacy. TikTok use, negative emotions (anger, disappointment, resentment), political distrust, and anti-establishment party support significantly increase the likelihood of viewing the decision as illegitimate, whereas trust in journalists reduces it. The study contributes to the literature on populism as a communicative style and emotional register, showing how legitimacy itself becomes a contested symbol in digital environments marked by personalization, fragmentation, and affective intensification. We argue that institutional legitimacy is no longer grounded solely in procedural legality but is increasingly shaped by emotionally resonant narratives circulating through digital platforms. We complement the survey with a headline-level media analysis (N = 3,923; Dec 2024 - Aug 2025), to serve as a contextual counterfactual: instead of escalating antagonism, mainstream media gradually stabilize institutional language. A keyness comparison shows that the

Early window (first 14 days) is driven by institutional/legal terms (CCR, decision, annulment), while the Late window becomes actor-centric (Simion, Antonescu, Ponta, Bolojan). Over time, lexical entropy declines markedly, signaling a standardization of vocabulary around procedural frames rather than escalating antagonism. Taken together, the results point to a decoupling between media normalization and individual affect, suggesting that democratic legitimacy in platformized communication environments is increasingly produced through affective legitimacy rather than procedural authority.

Read article →

Entertainment as Trojan Horse: Voluntary Consumption of Propaganda in China

2026-08-13 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2701201

Hanzhang Liu; Linan Yao

Florida State University; Vanderbilt University

Abstract. For authoritarian propaganda to change hearts and minds, it must first reach the masses and capture their attention. In an era of media proliferation, what can an authoritarian regime do to make ordinary citizens consume pro-regime propaganda voluntarily? How can it lower citizens' resistance to being indoctrinated? In this article, we answer these questions by studying a new generation of propaganda movies in contemporary China. Leveraging observational data and a pre-registered survey experiment, we find that entertainment elements in propaganda movies - both personality-based and narrative-based - play a key role in appealing to viewers and increasing consumption; this effect is especially pronounced among groups that are the least inclined to expose themselves to propaganda in the first place. Also, viewers are more receptive to political indoctrination when it is interwoven with entertainment, even when they recognize such content. Combined, these findings highlight the importance of entertainment in authoritarian propaganda: not only does it serve as a vehicle to disseminate political indoctrination, but it also functions as a source of appeal that renders such indoctrination more palatable to the masses.

Read article →

Kamala is Brat: TikTok and the Affective Politics of Memes

2026-08-12 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2715697

Laura Cervi; Sarah J. Jackson

Autonomous University of Barcelona; University of Pennsylvania

Abstract. In this article, we examine TikTok memes about former Vice president Kamala Harris that circulated through the digital registers of the Charli XCX-inspired "Kamala is Brat" trend. By analyzing the form, function, and affective resonance of these memes, we explore how creators interpreted and reframed Harris's image leading up to the 2024 U.S. presidential election. Using a multimodal analysis, we introduce a three-layer analytic that distinguishes memetic form, communicative function, and affective character. Our findings show how creators mobilized recognizable meme templates, narrative positioning, and affective cues to recast Harris through identity-signaling and aesthetic contrast to her opponent. We also find that TikTok's features enabled a pop culture intertextuality in which other viral trends - including the appeal of "it girl" Julia Fox, and the symbolic ambiguity of signifiers ranging from Pulp Fiction, The Matrix, and coconuts - become linked to the candidate. We argue that platform-native meme cultures on TikTok operate as mechanisms of vernacular electoral mediation, enabling creators to reinterpret candidate imagery and political narratives through the aesthetic conventions of platform culture. In doing so, this work demonstrates how participatory meme practices contribute to the symbolic construction of electoral candidates in contemporary digital media environments.

Read article →

Policing the Political Boundary: How the r/BarstoolSports Audience Confronts Politicization

2026-08-12 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2715700

Elliott Edsall

University of Minnesota - Twin Cities

Abstract. Recent scholarship attends to politicized popular cultural spaces. Scarcely understood is how audiences of these spaces contend with this scrutiny. In response, I introduce the concept of anti-political space to describe how fans of politicized media spatially distinguish popular cultural spaces from institutional politics. This is conceptualized through a critical discourse analysis of the official Barstool Sports (Barstool) subreddit from 2019 to 2025, where fans share critical news coverage of Barstool. Across 16 analyzed threads, criticism is rendered unfounded or demonstrative of politically obsessed liberal culture. I argue fans' varied expressions of victimhood and estrangement, while nominally defending against politicization, showcase how reactionary political discourse appears beyond institutional political spaces. Theoretically, this analysis recognizes how symbolic contests over what constitutes politics occur through boundary work. As the political relevance of popular cultural spaces increases in the contemporary media landscape, this analysis underscores how boundary work defends against the felt intrusion of politics into popular culture. Amid broader sociotechnical changes, I suggest anti-political spaces are poised to be a continued feature of the contemporary media environment.

Read article →

Examining the Influence of Media Coverage on Information-Seeking of Judicial Candidates

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2716378

Marcy Shieh

University of Wisconsin-Whitewater

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

Trending Topics, Growing Knowledge? How Curating Actors' Political Social Media Content Affects Youth's Political Knowledge

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2708127

Margot Lissens; Cato Waeterloos; Laura Vandenbosch; Desiree Schmuck

KU Leuven; University of Vienna

Abstract. Whether youth can gain political knowledge through social media is long debated. Existing research has insufficiently accounted for different curating actors of political information, an indirect learning logic, and within-person changes. To fill these gaps, we conducted a large-scale three-wave panel study among 16- to 30-year-olds (NT3 = 2276) to examine how exposure to different social media actors such as politicians, peers, or influencers relates to the acquisition of current affairs knowledge over time. We investigated perceived opinion leadership gratifications as a novel underlying mechanism in this process. While increased exposure to all curating actors' political content was related to higher opinion leadership gratifications in the same wave, we found little indirect learning effects over time on the within-person level through obtained gratifications. This association emerged only during the national election period, when perceived opinion leadership gratifications from peers' political content were linked to above-usual gains in objective political knowledge over time.

Read article →

American Journal of Political Science

(Non)belonging and (un)freedom

2026-08-13 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70081

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Abstract. Abstract This article centers on the concept of "belonging" to argue that belonging and freedom are fundamentally related, and that this relationship cannot be easily captured in formal terms alone. I contend that experiences of incomplete belonging among citizens deserve attention from political science because, in addition to their more obvious challenge to equality, they also erode freedom, even in the context of robust formal guarantees. Citizens perceived as not fully belonging are more likely to eschew behaviors or opinions they know can exacerbate the likelihood of being perceived as interlopers. But although this challenge to individual freedom may be by itself worrisome, I focus on the ways in which some citizens' unequal belonging undermines collective freedom-what Hannah Arendt calls political freedom-by confining some people's sincere expressions to narrow public spaces, limiting pluralism, and depleting the public space of opportunities for deliberation and political action.

Read article →

Global harms, local profits: How the uneven costs of natural disasters affect support for green political platforms

2026-08-13 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70078

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Abstract. Abstract Largescale fires are becoming increasingly common due to climate change. While conventional wisdom suggests that firsthand experiences with natural disasters foster green coalitions by raising awareness of environmental degradation, we propose an alternative view: Natural disasters can heighten the perceived tradeoff between economic development and environmental policies. This study examines the case of Brazil, where largescale fires, by clearing natural vegetation, create new opportunities for land grabbing and the expansion of agriculture and livestock production. Using satellite, administrative, and electoral data, we provide evidence that largescale fires increase support for green candidates only in municipalities that are unlikely to reap economic benefits from fires. Survey data further indicate that voters prioritize environmental protection over economic growth only when they stand to receive limited or no benefit from the newly cleared land. Our findings suggest that the potential for natural disasters to foster green coalitions is contingent upon distributive concerns.

Read article →

Durable majority gerrymanders: Where partisan gerrymandering can displace democracy

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70074

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Abstract. Abstract We develop the concept of, and estimation tools for, durable majority gerrymanders : electoral district maps drawn to reduce an opposing political party's probability of winning a majority in a legislative chamber. Directly interpretable, forwardlooking, and motivated by the democratic principle that a party in power should have some chance of losing it, this measure provides new insights into the role of redistricting in state legislative elections. We show that, when map drawers are unconstrained, the ability to create durable majorities is so widespread that at least one party in every state can draw a map where a majority of legislative districts withstand almost any likely future electoral swing. Enacted maps are less durable due to a combination of underlying geography, voter partisanship, and statelevel guidelines. This paper provides the theoretical framework and empirical tools to understand which gerrymandered maps enable statelevel majorities to emerge and to endure.

Read article →

Endogenous coalition formation in policy debates

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70079

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Abstract. Abstract Political actors form coalitions around their joint normative beliefs in order to influence the policy process on contentious issues such as climate change or population aging. Policy process theory maintains that learning within and across coalitions is a central predictor of policy change but has yet to explain how policy learning works. This article explains the formation and maintenance of coalitions by focusing on the ways actors adopt policy beliefs from other actors in policy debates. A policy debate is a complex social system in which temporal network dependence guides how actors contribute ideological statements. Belief adoption matters in three complementary ways: bonding , which exploits cues within coalitions; bridging , which explores new beliefs outside one's perimeter; and repulsion , which reinforces polarization between coalitions and cements their belief systems. We formalize this theory of endogenous coalition formation in policy debates and test it on a microlevel empirical data set.

Read article →

Nature Human Behaviour

Uneven patterns of cross-border media coverage following natural disasters

2026-08-14 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02512-6

Thiemo Fetzer; Prashant Garg

Abstract. Abstract Many natural disasters central to climate-policy debates are hydro-meteorological hazards, yet it remains unclear how media attention is distributed across disaster types. Using 135 million news articles from 466 sources in 123 countries since 2016, we estimated cross-border reporting changes after disasters. Attention rises but is highly uneven (95% confidence intervals are shown in parentheses after the estimates): short-run increases are largest following earthquakes (= 0.0785 (0.0758, 0.0812)), dry-mass movements (= 0.0531 (0.0349, 0.0713)) and volcanic eruptions (= 0.0425 (0.0359, 0.0490)), and smaller for floods (= 0.0069 (0.0062, 0.0076)) and droughts (= 0.0001 (0.0036, 0.0039)). Conditional on severity and duration, hydro-meteorological disasters receive less attention than geophysical disasters (= 0.0065 (0.0115, 0.0015)). Coverage is higher for 100+ versus 0-9 deaths (= 0.0360 (0.0231, 0.0490)), with stronger fatality gradients for country pairs with tighter social ties (= 0.1498 (0.0822, 0.2174)) and ancestral relatedness (= 0.2965 (0.1887, 0.4043)).

Read article →

Homophily in grant evaluations

2026-08-13 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02554-W

Nicola Fuchs-Schundeln; Felix Holub

Abstract. Abstract Funding agencies play a central role in science by awarding grants to researchers. Grant review can be influenced by bias, including preferences for applicants who share reviewers' gender, country or citizenship. Using 37,073 applications for European Research Council grants with multiple reviews per proposal, we show that reviewers who share an applicant's country of work or citizenship award higher scores than reviewers with no such match. This effect is strongest when both country and citizenship align. Shared gender increases scores to a smaller extent. Further analyses indicate that these findings are unlikely to be driven by shared tastes or informational advantages. At the panel level, correlational evidence shows that applicants are more likely to advance past the first stage when the chair or more panel members share

their country of work or citizenship. Country of work and citizenship may therefore be relevant sources of bias in international grant review.

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Nature Communications

Public institutions for cleantech commercialization in the United States

2026-08-13 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-76484-6

Em Finkelstine; Laura Diaz Anadon; Jonas Meckling

Abstract. Abstract The United States has been building public institutions to promote cleantech commercialization since the 1970s oil crisis. The ascent of new industrial policy has accelerated this process substantially since 2020, resulting in a doubling of the total number of institutions by 2024. Introducing a dataset of 122 institutions, we show how institutions perform five functions: goal setting, coordination, derisking, imposing discipline, and external engagement. Further, we demonstrate how post-2020 institutions extend and diverge from historical trends, highlighting the recent buildout of planning capacity, the widespread use of conditionalities, and the pivot toward engagement with local and non-firm actors. We conclude with an analysis of how the second Trump administration is transforming the cleantech commercialization system through retrenching, redesigning, repurposing, and maintaining institutions. We offer a bottom-up, institution-level examination of the emergence and evolution of state capacity for green industrial policy in the United States, its functions, and current developments.

Read article →

Strategic objectives underpin national climate pledges

2026-08-13 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-76467-7

Taryn Fransen; Jonas Meckling

Abstract. Abstract Emissions-reduction pledges under the Paris Agreement are commonly understood as expressions of domestic preferences. Recent scholarship, however, suggests that governments may also use climate pledges strategically to shape the behavior of other political actors. Here, we provide an empirical account of these strategic objectives based on in-depth interviews with 40 policymakers and experts. We identify six key strategic objectives: attracting international climate finance, setting standards for others, enhancing status, preserving credibility, facilitating domestic action, and pre-committing future governments. International actors emerge as the primary target audience. These objectives have distinct implications for ambition. While most encourage stronger pledges, concerns about credibility can constrain ambition. In an exploratory analysis, we also examine how strategic objectives vary across countries. The findings suggest that higher emitters and states with lower levels of democratic institutionalization place greater emphasis on long-term credibility, while countries eligible for climate finance seek to attract it regardless of income or vulnerability. Our findings have implications for ratcheting up international climate commitments.

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The choice-wide behavioral association study: data-driven identification of interpretable behavioral components

2026-08-13 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-76681-3

David B. Kastner; Nicole O. Yokota; Christina Y. Lee; Cristofer Holobetz; Ali Chaudhry; Greer Williams; Jane N. Ton; Mihika Mehra; Viktor Kharazia; Dilworth Y. Parkinson; Joseph P. Romano; Peter Dayan

Abstract. Abstract Behavior contains rich structure across many timescales. However, there is a dearth of methods to identify relevant components, especially over the longer periods required for learning and decision-making. Inspired by the

goals and techniques of genome-wide association studies, we present a data-driven method-the choice-wide behavioral association study: CBAS-that systematically identifies such behavioral features. CBAS extracts sequences of actions or choices that either significantly differ between groups or correlate with a covariate of interest, using a powerful resampling-based method to correct for multiple comparisons. We illustrate CBAS through application to tasks performed by flies, rats, and humans, showing that it provides unexpected and interpretable information in each case.

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Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

The effectiveness of green place-based industrial policy: Evidence from the Inflation Reduction Act

2026-08-14 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2600276123

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Abstract. Governments across the globe are turning to place-based industrial policies to make the green transition more equitable and politically palatable. The United States' Inflation Reduction Act exemplifies this approach through its "Energy Community" provisions, which offer additional tax incentives for clean energy projects in regions reliant on fossil fuels. We use spatially granular data on renewable energy investment, employment, and voting, and document that these incentives substantially increased local solar investment, but we do not find significant impacts on wind investment, job creation, or political preferences. Estimated abatement costs are well below the social cost of carbon and lower than those of other major U.S. climate policies. The results suggest that place-based green industrial policies can effectively direct clean energy investment toward disadvantaged regions, but their capacity to generate broader local economic or political benefits may be limited.

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Tariff policy and why economics needs intergroup psychology

2026-08-12 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2514670123

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Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Mitigating China's food-related water scarcity and spatial inequality via integrated basin-city management

2026-08-11 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2610855123

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Abstract. Food production is constrained by water availability at the basin scale, whereas the governance of food trade primarily operates at the city scale. This spatial mismatch hinders the sustainable development of both food and water systems. To bridge this gap, we develop an integrated framework that combines hydrological (basin) and administrative (city) scales and apply it to China to quantify how virtual water flows embedded in food trade affect inequality in water allocation across and within basins. Our results show that 38% of scarce water is traded across basins, exacerbating interbasin inequality by 6%. In contrast, approximately 30% of scarce water is embodied in intrabasin trade, which alleviates intrabasin inequality. Single-scale interventions, whether through production or consumption adjustments, involve trade-offs among interbasin equality, intrabasin equality, and total water savings. By contrast, an integrated basin-city management strategy at a 50% intervention intensity reduces interbasin inequality by 7% and achieves water savings equivalent to more than four-fifths (80%) of total water use in the Yangtze River basin. It also outperforms existing province-city vertical management models across scales. These findings provide valuable insights for developing global virtual water management strategies that integrate both hydrological and administrative perspectives.

Read article →

The rise of large language models and the direction and impact of US federal research funding

2026-08-11 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2601439123

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Abstract. Federal research funding shapes the direction, diversity, and impact of the US scientific enterprise. Large language models (LLMs) are rapidly diffusing into scientific practice, holding substantial promise while raising widespread concerns. Despite growing attention to AI use in scientific writing and evaluation, little is known about how the rise of LLMs is reshaping the public funding landscape. Here, we examine LLM involvement at key stages of the federal funding pipeline by combining two complementary data sources: confidential NSF and NIH proposal submissions from two large US R1 universities, including funded, unfunded, and pending proposals, and the full population of publicly released NSF and NIH awards. We find that LLM use rises sharply beginning in 2023 and exhibits a bimodal distribution, indicating a clear split between minimal and substantive use. Across both private submissions and public awards, higher LLM involvement is consistently associated with lower semantic distinctiveness, positioning projects closer to recently funded work within the same agency. The consequences of this shift are agency-dependent. LLM use is positively associated with proposal success and higher early-stage publication output at NIH, whereas no comparable associations are observed at NSF. Notably, the productivity gains at NIH are concentrated in nonhit papers rather than the most highly cited work. Together, these findings provide large-scale evidence that the rise of LLMs is reshaping how scientific ideas are positioned, selected, and translated into publicly funded research, with implications for portfolio governance, research diversity, and the long-run impact of science.

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A budding science of illegal markets

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2511780123

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Abstract. Illegal markets create untold societal and environmental harm, but they have attracted surprisingly little scholarly attention. This paper explores illegal markets as a class of objects. It considers similarities and differences across markets, with particular attention to nine: human smuggling, commercial sex, firearms, money laundering, illegal fishing, international wildlife trafficking, counterfeit goods, drugs, and tobacco products. These nine markets display enormous variation, stemming in part from differences in the "physics" of the good or service they provide. Other differences can be seen as adaptations to

different policy and enforcement pressures. Some markets have changed in fundamental ways over recent decades, while others remain more stable. The overall rate of true innovation is not necessarily high, but most appear quick to adopt innovations that are created by the larger economy such as cryptocurrencies, secure communications, and dark web distribution. Low rates of investment in research and development, branding, and marketing along with simultaneous high rates of adaptability may be a natural outgrowth of these markets being dominated by relatively small organizations. It is hypothesized that one can group the common illegal markets into those that: 1) Supply goods stolen from a common heritage, either natural (illegal fishing, wildlife trafficking, illegal mining) or cultural (antiquities); 2) Supply goods or services to people committing crimes beyond just consuming the banned products (guns, money laundering); 3) Undermine an authority's rights (smuggling humans across borders, counterfeiting goods, tax-evading cigarettes); and 4) Supply products that harm the user and/or seller (drugs, commercial sex, gambling, raw milk).

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A descriptive analysis for the markets for counterfeit products

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2522322123

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Philip Morris International

Abstract. Product counterfeiting is a pervasive crime that involves the unauthorized use of a legitimate trademark, a violation of intellectual property rights. Counterfeiting is also one of many forms of global illicit trade, mirroring legitimate markets in structure and reach. Counterfeit goods span nearly every product category from luxury items and electronics to pharmaceuticals and military components, posing risks that range from consumer deception to threats to public health. The globalization of commerce and trade and the rise of e-commerce and social media have significantly expanded counterfeiters' reach, enabling them to exploit legitimate supply chains and marketplaces and reach consumers around the world. The production and distribution of counterfeit goods often involve sophisticated networks, including legitimate businesses and transnational criminal organizations, and are sometimes linked to human trafficking and forced labor. Despite regulatory efforts and public-private partnerships aimed at curbing counterfeiting, enforcement remains challenging due to the complexity of global supply chains and the difficulty in distinguishing counterfeit operations from legitimate ones. This article describes what product counterfeiting is and addresses how markets for counterfeit goods represent an illicit parallel market that is in many ways intermingled with aspects of legitimate markets. The role of consumers as drivers of demand for counterfeits is addressed, and motivations for consumers' willful purchase of counterfeit goods are explored. This article also provides exploratory insights about the supply chains for some of these products

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Americans favor predistributive over redistributive economic policies

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2617191123

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Center for Socio- Political Data and Center for European Studies and Comparative Politics, Sciences Po; Department of Sociology, Stanford University

Abstract. Redistributive policies designed to reduce economic inequality through taxes and transfers (e.g., safety-net benefits funded by progressive taxation) receive less support in the United States than in many Western democracies. Recent work suggests Americans may be more receptive to "predistributive" policies, which seek to reduce economic inequality before taxes and transfers (e.g., minimum-wage increases). Yet existing evidence leaves open whether this support gap characterizes contemporary Americans overall, and whether it persists when the same policy proposals are described in predistributive vs. redistributive terms, with their core provisions held constant. Across 31 national U.S. survey waves from 2015 to 2024 (total N = 384 , 248), we find greater support for policies classified as predistributive than redistributive. We then fielded a preregistered experiment with a national U.S. sample (N = 1 , 009), randomly varying whether otherwise identical policy proposals were described as increasing earnings for people lower in the income

distribution, shifting resources from higher- to lower-income individuals, or presented only with the policy description given in all conditions. Support was higher under predistributive than redistributive descriptions. Comparison with the control condition clarifies this difference: Predistributive descriptions received support comparable to control, whereas redistributive descriptions received lower support. Exploratory analyses suggest perceived respect for hard work and beneficiary deservingness were associated with the support gap. Together, these results suggest Americans prefer policies that reduce inequality by influencing earnings more than through taxes and transfers.

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Casting light on the workings of illegal fishing markets

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2512081123

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Abstract. About 3.5 million fishing vessels ply the world's oceans, providing livelihoods and food for millions of people. Sound management is key to fisheries' sustainability, but illegal fishing, along with fishing overcapacity generally and environmental change, are putting many fisheries at risk. Illegal fishing is a globally pervasive yet unevenly distributed phenomenon, manifesting in diverse forms across both small-scale and industrial-scale fleets, the latter accounting for about 82 to 93% of the 8.4 to 15.4 million metric tons global annual illicit marine wild fish seafood trade valued at US$6.2 to 12.2 billion. The massive rise in fishing effort since 1950 has not been matched by adequate regulations and enforcement, especially for industrial-scale fishing in the waters of developing countries. About two-thirds of the illicit trade by value originates from fishing grounds in West Africa (27%), East Asia (24%), and Southeast Asia (16%). Remote sensing and AI technologies are improving detection of illegal fishing, but enforcement remains an issue given its high costs and the relative ease of laundering illegal catch through transshipments at sea, poorly regulated ports, and fraudulent documentation along seafood supply chains. Illegal fishing markets require multilayered policy responses grounded in transparency, international cooperation, and socioeconomic justice. Proposed measures, ranging from mandatory electronic vessel identification and subsidy reform to artisanal fishery protections and stronger port controls, warrant further research into their implementation and effectiveness.

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Historical slavery predicts contemporary disparities in mortality between Black and White Americans

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2508037123

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Abstract. We tested whether contemporary Black-White mortality disparities in the United States may be rooted in the historical legacy of slavery and perpetuated through structural inequalities. Linking county-level data on the proportion of enslaved people in 1860 with structural inequality indicators from 1990 to 2000 and mortality outcomes from 2010 to 2020, we find that historical slavery is robustly associated with contemporary racial mortality gaps. Our model estimates ~22 additional deaths per 100,000 among Black Americans relative to White Americans for every 10% increase in the 1860 enslaved population. Path analysis models showed that segregation, economic inequality, and racial disparities in poverty and education statistically mediated this effect. We test the plausibility of a causal pathway using an instrumental variable analysis and explore the robustness of our theoretical model in multiple supplemental analyses. Our analyses held even after controlling for a comprehensive suite of historical and contemporary covariates. These findings are consistent with a model wherein slavery's legacy continues to shape present-day Black-White racial health disparities via enduring structural

inequities.

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How illegal wildlife trade adheres to and defies conventional market behavior

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2525056123

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Abstract. Illegal wildlife markets comprise a complex global economy generating criminal profits while harming biodiversity and livelihoods. The negative externalities from biodiversity loss, ecosystem destabilization, and zoonotic disease risk may be orders of magnitude larger than the multibillion dollar annual total market value. Despite decades of international policy attention, fundamental economic characteristics of these markets remain poorly understood. We suggest distinguishing three categories of illegally traded wildlife products based on product durability and intended use: luxury durable goods, nondurable products processed to be food or medicine, and live or perishable exotic pets and plants. Through case studies of elephant ivory, pangolin scales, and succulent plants, we characterize market organization, pricing structures, supply network architecture, and regulatory vulnerabilities across product types. Our analysis suggests illegal wildlife markets exhibit economic characteristics distinguishing them from other illegal markets, including biological production constraints creating absolute supply limits, opportunistic supply networks exploiting existing legal trade infrastructure, and extreme markup structures leaving harvesters with a fraction of final retail value. We conclude by proposing the concept of Accelerating Demand for Novel or eXclusive Assets, or AD NOXA, which describes how scarcity may paradoxically increase rather than decrease the appeal of consuming certain wildlife markets. This paradox creates feedback loops that may drive species toward extinction, despite-or because of-protective regulations and fundamentally limits the effectiveness of supply-side interventions. Policy responses may be more effective when they integrate supply-side enforcement with demand reduction strategies tailored to the distinct characteristics of illegal wildlife markets.

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Illegal firearms markets: Transaction patterns, evolving sources, and importance in criminal misuse

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2509754122

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RAND Corporation; Sanford School of Public Policy, Duke University

Abstract. In the United States, the legal status of the 30 to 40 million annual firearms transactions is defined by state and federal regulations. These regulations primarily aim to reduce criminal misuse while preserving access for the large majority of adults who lack a serious criminal record or are otherwise proscribed from possession. Illegal firearms transactions are embedded in the "formal market"-sales, mostly of new guns, by licensed retail dealers required to screen purchasers and maintain records-and the "informal market," where any of the 80 million gun owners may act as a source. A growing fraction of illegal transactions involve privately made firearms, fabricated from commercial kits or additive manufacturing techniques. The firearms used by proscribed people are diverted from the legal supply chain, in some cases by professional intermediaries (thieves, straw purchasers, scofflaw dealers, home fabricators). Subsequent redistribution may involve professional brokers and traffickers. Most such enterprises are small in scale, with organized criminal groups serving primarily as customers rather than distributors. Compared with the drug trade, the illegal gun market is smaller and more exposed to law enforcement. For proscribed buyers, transaction costs are highly differentiated, varying based on the local prevalence of guns, state regulations and enforcement, and individual connections. While preventing dangerous people from obtaining guns is intrinsically difficult in a regime designed for broad accessibility to most adults, regulations can substantially affect illegal commerce, and some regulations reduce criminal use.

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Illegal markets for cigarettes and e-cigarettes

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2512084122

Donald Kenkel; Grace Phillips

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Abstract. This paper discusses the long-standing illegal markets for cigarettes and the more recently emerged illegal markets for e-cigarettes. We identify three distinctive market fundamentals that help explain many features of the illegal markets. First, in contrast to some illegal goods, many countries have sizable legal markets for cigarettes and e-cigarettes alongside the illegal markets. In 2024, tobacco products generated almost $1 trillion in revenues; e-cigarettes generated $26 billion dollars. It is estimated that illegal markets account for about 10 percent of global cigarette consumption. Second, the illegal markets have arisen to evade high excise taxes that increase prices and regulations that restrict the availability of desirable features of legal products. The taxes and regulations have been adopted as public health measures with the goal of reducing tobacco consumption; however, these same policies drive the formation of illegal markets. Third, demand-side linkages mean that taxation, regulatory, and enforcement policies targeted at legal and illegal markets for cigarettes will affect legal and illegal markets for e-cigarettes, and vice versa. The connection between the markets means regulatory policy for one product can drive consumers both to the illegal market for the product and to the legal and illegal market for the other product.

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The illegal market for sex in the United States: Insights from economic research

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2512375122

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Abstract. The illegal market for sex in the United States generates significant economic activity yet remains understudied due to its illegality and clandestine nature. This paper synthesizes existing empirical evidence documenting aspects of market structure, impacts of regulation, and notable changes over time. Criminalization, while intended to suppress the market, often exacerbates harms by displacing activity underground, increasing violence against sex workers, and elevating disease transmission risks. Natural experiments, including decriminalization episodes in Rhode Island and policy shifts in Europe, reveal that decriminalization can reduce sexually transmitted infections and violence against women. Additionally, technological shifts-particularly the rise of online platforms due to the internet-have reshaped market organization. These findings challenge conventional legal and moral frameworks and underscore the need for evidence-based policymaking to guide effective regulation of sex markets.

Read article →

The market for human smuggling: Structure, mechanisms, and paradoxes

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2511019122

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Abstract. Human smuggling is the facilitation of unlawful cross-border movement. It is primarily a commercial activity, offered as a service to willing, paying customers, and a large-scale market catering to millions seeking to circumvent mobility restrictions. Contrary to prevailing media and political narratives that depict smuggling as dominated by powerful and highly sophisticated criminal organizations, this study documents a fragmented, decentralized market composed of independent, localized actors operating through flexible, often temporary networks. These flexible arrangements, coupled with low barriers to entry, confer resilience and adaptability to the market, making enforcement difficult and resource-intensive. Intensified enforcement often produces unintended consequences, including heightened migrant vulnerability and increased reliance on smugglers. Despite regional differences, smuggling operations exhibit striking structural similarities shaped by local

knowledge and monitoring costs. Such enduring structural characteristics exist alongside a growing role played by communication technologies, which are reshaping dynamics between service providers and customers. Ultimately, human smuggling remains a market fraught with paradoxes: Migrants face severe risks yet view smugglers as essential facilitators, while states confront the complex task of balancing border enforcement with humanitarian obligations and protections of vulnerable individuals.

Read article →

The policy construction of illegal markets: Exploring variation, success, failure, and unintended consequences

2026-08-10 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2515300123

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Abstract. Illegal markets, broadly defined to include markets where only specific transactions are illegal, are the consequence of policy, either a prohibition or highly restrictive regulation. They are generated by a variety of concerns, some moral, some pragmatic. They are often tied to legal markets, complicating the policy process. These markets are ubiquitous, rarely well controlled and little studied as markets. This article examines variations in illegality from the case studies in this Special Feature and synthesizes what can be learned about the success and failure of different approaches to controlling these markets. Control is often weak because powerful legal interests are opposed to tight regulation and, especially in markets with large underlying demand, rarely leads to substantial reductions in the targeted activity, unless draconian methods are used. As demonstrated by drug markets, tough enforcement can have large adverse collateral consequences. The paper concludes by suggesting that an extension of the harm reduction framework developed specifically for drug policy can be applied usefully to making policy choices in controlling other illegal markets.

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Science Advances

AI agents can coordinate via majority-following beyond human scale

2026-08-14 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEA6091

Giordano De Marzo; Claudio Castellano; David Garcia

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Abstract. Large language models (LLMs) are increasingly deployed in collaborative tasks forming "AI agent societies" where agents interact and influence one another. Whether such groups can spontaneously coordinate without external influence, a hallmark of self-organized regulation in human societies, remains an open question. Here, we use principles from complexity and behavioral science to investigate coordination in AI agent groups through majority-following, a fundamental mechanism for spontaneous consensus formation. Using binary opinion dynamics experiments across multiple LLM architectures and group sizes, we find that agents exhibit majority-following characterized by a universal functional form with a single parameter, the "majority force." This majority force diminishes as group size increases, leading to a critical size beyond which coordination becomes unattainable. The critical group size grows rapidly with model capabilities and, for advanced LLMs, exceeds 1000 agents, larger than typical human informal groups. Our findings have implications for designing collaborative AI systems where coordination could be beneficial or pose safety threats.

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Science

A democracy tax in support of science

2026-08-13 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEL2482

John Palfrey

John Palfrey is president of the John D. and Catherine T. MacArthur Foundation, Chicago, IL, USA.

Abstract. Over the past 19 months, the devastating effects of federal cuts to science funding in the United States have become plain: Young researchers are leaving scientific fields. Labs are struggling to fund promising projects, limiting hiring, training, and sometimes shuttering altogether. Data collected over decades will instead collect dust, ending future scientific discovery and innovation. But perhaps the most serious consequence has been overlooked-the importance of free scientific inquiry to democracy.

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Nature

Undocumented migration does not raise crime rates, huge study finds

2026-08-14 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-02542-0

Miryam Naddaf

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Agentic profiles for effective AI governance

2026-08-12 · DOI 10.1038/S41586-026-10805-Z

Atoosa Kasirzadeh; Iason Gabriel

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Towards an equitable future of global photovoltaic waste recycling

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Abstract. The world is confronting an escalating crisis of burgeoning photovoltaic (PV) waste1. However, the effectiveness and scalability of prevailing PV waste management approaches remain unclear owing to considerable heterogeneity across regions and over time. Here we develop a comprehensive framework to evaluate the economic and climate benefits of local versus outsourced recycling, covering mainstream technologies. Considering supply-side material constraints, global PV waste will reach 297-402 million tonnes by 2060, with middle-income regions such as China becoming major contributors after 2040. Notwithstanding anticipated technological advancements, the break-even point for global PV waste recycling remains more than a decade away. Combining region-specific recycling technologies with outsourced recycling strategies yields the maximal global net benefits, reducing greenhouse gas emissions by up to 3.32 billion tonnes of CO2-equivalent and generating cumulative net benefits of US$529.1-935.5 billion by 2060. However, outsourced recycling raises inequality concerns for low-income regions. Our results show that a well-designed declining-subsidy scheme effectively mitigates these inequalities, particularly in the early stages. We suggest that regionally adapted recycling strategies and international

cooperation, with a focus on technology transfer and funding for recycling capacity in low-income regions, provide effective ways to achieve equitable and scalable PV waste circularity.

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